Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on William Shakespeare's "[Since brass, nor stone, nor earth, nor boundless sea]"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of the speaker's argument that his sonnet will stand the test of time, thus the beauty of the person being addressed in Shakespeare's "[Since brass, nor stone, nor earth, nor boundless sea]" will be eternized include

alliteration,
ambiguity,
anaphora,
contrast,
couplet,
feminine rhyme,
iambic pentameter,
imagery,
inversion,
masculine rhyme,
metaphor,
meter,
paradox,
personification,
polysyndeton,
reification,
rhetorical question,
rhyme,
rhythm,
sigmatism,
simile,
syncope (elision),
theme, and
tone.

As with many of the Bard's sonnets, the major thematic concern of Sonnet 65 is found in the couplet. The contestant should recognize the couplet to be an answer to the several rhetorical questions that crowd the first three stanzas of the poem and should comment on the speaker's contention that "in this miracle"—the poem, the "black ink" (lines 13-14)—the beauty that is both the subject of his poem and the object of his love (line 14)—here the LitCritter might note the inherent ambiguity, in this context, of the word *love*—will survive despite the ravages of Time.

Any additional, complementary, endeavor to contrast the poem's own probability of success at eternizing—making eternal—the beauty of the person about whom the speaker is speaking with personified Time's effect and its attendant certainty of decay (line 8) on all things, including brass, stone, the sea, etc., strengthens the young writer's thesis.